

could arrange a new marriage for Placidia. The elevation of a claimant to the throne indebted to the Vandals, whose support would have come from the adherents of Licinia Eudoxia, could have truly presented Gaiseric, both in the West and in the East, as an "advocate of the empire" and furthermore been of great benefit for the future. When Alaric's committed actions fifty years prior had seized Rome, they reminded him of Priscus Attalus, his own²² August. And Theoderich wanted to attempt a similar step with Aetius as early as 456.²³ This unified backing by Amalus and Avienus was lacking in Italy, which is why Gaiseric, instead of pursuing the grand and long-term plans Wirth attributes to him, took the opportunity to strengthen his own position through a connection with the long-reigning dynasty of Gaiseric, the plunder of Rome by Gaiseric, the capture of the emperors' daughters at this time, and the capture of the emperors at this time. According to Priscus, the murder of Valentinian III and the subsequent unrest in Rome primarily provided Gaiseric with an immediate opportunity to strengthen his own position.²⁴ The king was certainly well-informed about the events, even without direct contact with Licinia Eudoxia or her entourage, and knew that given the division within the Roman army, no serious military resistance was to be expected.²⁵ This was all the more true for the type of swift strike operations that the Vandals had already carried out multiple times with astonishing success.²⁶ The fact that the treaty of 442 had been suspended due to Valentinian's death and likely not reaffirmed by Petronius Maximus could also be interpreted as a hostile act, thus justifying the Vandalic intentions.²⁷ After Gaiseric had taken Rome as planned, he carried everything out of the city that could be considered valuable in any way. This naturally included both coined and uncoined precious metals, as well as prominent captives. The empress dowager, her two daughters, Aetius' son Gaudentius, and several senators were for Gaiseric not only potential sources of ransom but primarily political pawns of inestimable value.²⁸ Even without already more extensive plans,

22. Regarding Alaric, cf. Demandt, 1989, p. 144 f., regarding Avitus, see below VIII.1.2.

23. Prisc. frg. 30,1 J. Antioch. frg. 201,6. Καὶ Γίζριχος τὸν Βανδύλων ἄρχων τὸν ἑταίρου καὶ Βαλεντινιανὸν φιλοῦν ἠρώκῃ ἠρώτας ἐπιτιθεμένοι τὸς ἀλλήλους καὶ τὸν ἡγεσμένον, ὃς τὸς μὲν ἐρήνης θάνατον τὸν βασιλευντων λυσαμένης, τοῦ δὲ τὸν βασιλεῖαν παρελθόντος μὲν ἑξίχρεων νεκτοῦ μὲν ναι.

24. According to Priscus, the army was divided over Valentinian's succession (see above). – O'Flynn, 1983, p. 60 n. 12, suspects a collaboration between Gaiseric and Licinia Eudoxia, stating, "the imperial ladies could have escaped from Rome prior to Gaiseric's arrival had they seriously wished to do so." A voluntary stay in Rome could indeed provide clues about Licinia Eudoxia's own perspective, not about the general situation, but not necessarily about Gaiseric's intentions. Whether there were points of contact here is uncertain.

25. Thus during their crossing to Africa in 429 or the capture of Carthage ten years later. Similar actions also led to Gaiseric's successes against Majorian in 460 and against the East Roman fleet in 468. Cf. below VII.3.2.

26. Cf. Prisc. frg. 30,1 (see above, n. 52), Seeck, 1920, p. 324; Schmidt, 1942, p. 77 f.

27. PLRE II s.v. Gaudentius 7. Anicius Olybrius, however, Placidia's fiancé, escaped a similar fate, because he was in Constantinople in 455. Max, 1975, p. 63; Clover, 1978, pp. 176–179.

II.2 PETRONIUS MAXIMUS AND GAISERIC (March to June 455) to pursue with them, this consideration alone might have sufficiently motivated the Vandalic attack. Whether Gaiseric also saw himself in 455 as a protector of the Theodosian house and a proponent of a legitimate idea is, however, mostly uncertain.²⁷ The outcome of the roughly nine months between September 454 and June 455 proved to be a disaster for the Roman side: Two emperors had been murdered. The dynasty that had reigned for over sixty years was overthrown and the throne thereby vacant; the city plundered, the provinces restless, the previous consensus within the senatorial aristocracy irrevocably terminated. The crisis of 454/5 had created problems that would burden the Western Roman Empire for decades.²⁸

57. That Gaiseric primarily intended to make loot, as Proc. BV I 5,1 claims, is rejected by Clover, 1966, p. 145 f., and explained as a reflection of the impression left by the authors of the *treasures of 455* eighty years later by Procopius. In contrast, Courtois, 1955, p. 196, who, with Gautier, 1937, p. 38, views the conquest of Rome as “une magnifique entreprise de piraterie sur une très grande échelle, une affaire exceptionnellement fructueuse” apparently sees this as reality.

58. Eastern authors therefore later saw the beginning of the end in the murder of Aetius: Marc. Com. s. a. 454,2 = Chron. Min. II, p. 86: cum ipso (sc. Aetio) Hesperium cecidit regnum nec haetenus valuit relevari (thereafter Paul. Diac. hist. Rom. XIV 15). Similarly Proc. BV 14,28: Prisc. frg. 30,1 = J. Antioch. frg. 201,2 f. Marcellinus probably only reflects a tradition within the Anician historiography (thus Momigliano, 1956, p. 235 f; Wes, 1967, pp. 110–116 a. 170–173; Zecchini, 1981, p. 124). Priscus and Procopius, following him, show, however, that the death of Aetius was also understood as an overall Roman loss outside of the Anicians.